

Install Ubuntu with Kickstart and Save Precious Time

Automated or unattended installations are very useful when hundreds or sometimes thousands of installations have to be made. The common tools for this purpose are Kickstart, Jumpstart, Preseed, etc. This article discusses what Kickstart is and outlines the steps to use it to install Ubuntu.



In an environment where you have to install the Linux OS on hundreds or thousands of systems, doing manual installation is a tedious job and consumes lot of time for system administrators, effort and requires human intervention. The automatic or unattended or Kickstart based Linux OS installation saves lots of time for system administrators.

With Kickstart, the user or administrator can create a single file containing the answers to all the questions that would normally be asked during installation.

Kickstart will automate the installation, including:

- Basic configuration like language selection, location, time zone, etc.
- Installation methods like boot loader option and disk partitioning
- Network configuration
- User creation or configuration
- Package selection

The following are the advantages of a Kickstart-based installation over manual installation:

- Saves time and effort for administrators

- Avoids the errors of manual installation
- Manual installation is very tedious job when deploying on hundreds or thousands of systems or servers

Kickstart or unattended installations can be done using:

- CD-ROMs
- A local hard drive
- On a network via NFS, FTP or HTTP

How Kickstart-based installation works

The network-based Kickstart installation is widely used, as most installations are required to be performed on networked systems or servers.

In the usual set-up, there should be a system such as a DHCP/TFTP/HTTP server that provides the configuration information for installation over the network. To install on the server you will have to boot into PXE mode; the installation process starts and completes by retrieving all the requested packages from a repository server. See Figure 1 for the network-based Kickstart installation flow.